

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Audit raises concerns of OT abuse

Illinois Corrections’ employees on paid leave still took overtime pay

By **Jeremy Gorner**
Chicago Tribune

Illinois Department of Corrections employees were allowed to work overtime on the same days they were on paid leave, raising concerns by the state’s chief auditor that prison employees were abusing overtime, according to an audit released Tuesday.

The report from Auditor General Frank Mautino’s office, covering a two-year period through June 30,

2024, noted the corrections agency was called out by the state for this same issue a decade earlier and “management has been unsuccessful in implementing a corrective action plan to remedy this deficiency.”

This marks at least the second time within a year that Mautino’s office has flagged a state agency under Gov. JB Pritzker’s purview for problems related to excessive overtime. In December, Mautino’s office disclosed eye-opening

overtime issues from a previous two-year period among Illinois Department of Human Services employees as the agency saw an increase in misconduct allegations.

Pritzker on Tuesday said he hadn’t seen the new audit but sought to downplay its significance by noting state audits “are a year or two old when they come out” and then pivoted away from the findings to say “every industry” was having difficulty hiring, including state of Illinois departments.

“We’ve rectified that to a greater degree. We’ve hired quite a number of people. I think you’ve seen us announce that,” Pritzker said following an unrelated event in Joliet. “But, look, number one is we want our correctional officers to be safe. We want to have enough correctional officers at any given moment that are covering the prisons and all of their duties.”

“We don’t want to cross any of the rules of hiring but we also want to make sure that we’ve got enough people on the job to do the job when we need them,” he said.

According to the audit, Mauti-

no’s office reviewed timesheets and payroll reports for 10 employees each from the Stateville Correctional Center in Crest Hill and Dixon Correctional Center in Dixon and found 16 out of the 20 employees during fiscal year 2024 used a full day of benefit time at least once on the same day they worked an overtime shift. During the two-year period ending June 30, 2024, Mautino’s office identified 150 instances in which the 16 workers used a full day of leave time, which is 7 ½ hours, on the

Turn to Overtime, Page 6



BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Johnson celebrates bike lanes

Mayor Brandon Johnson, left, arrives with a group on Divvy bikes using the protected lanes on North Milwaukee Avenue on Tuesday for an event in Chicago’s West Town neighborhood to mark progress on building bikeways across the city. **Chicagoland**, Page 3

Trump assails UN and praises himself

Warns the world body of ruinous policies, hails his second term

By **Aamer Madhani**
and **Farnoush Amiri**
Associated Press

UNITED NATIONS — President Donald Trump castigated the United Nations as a feckless institution in a speech to the world body on Tuesday, praising the turn America has taken under his leadership while warning Europe will be ruined if it doesn’t turn away from a “double-tailed monster” of ill-conceived migration and green energy policies.

His roughly hourlong speech before the U.N. General Assembly was both grievance-filled and self-congratulatory as he used the platform to applaud his second-term achievements and lament that some of his fellow world leaders’ countries were “going to hell.”

The address was the latest reminder for U.S. allies and foes that the United States — after a four-year interim under the more internationalist President Joe Biden — has returned to an unapologetically “America First” posture with an antagonistic view toward the United Nations. Trump also sharply criticized the global body for inaction, saying it was filled with “empty words” that “don’t solve wars.”

“What is the purpose of the United Nations?” Trump said.

Turn to Trump, Page 10



Producers work in the control room while anchor Nichole Berlie broadcasts Sept. 15 at the Chicago studios of NewsNation. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

‘Scrappy’ NewsNation celebrates 5 years as Chicago-based network

Cable news channel now airs 24/7 and has carved out its niche

By **Robert Channick**
Chicago Tribune

Nexstar Media, the Dallas-based TV station owner at the center of the high-profile controversy over the preemption of Jimmy Kimmel’s late-night ABC show, may finally be realizing the potential of NewsNation, its five-year-old cable news network.

NewsNation’s coverage of slain conservative activist Charlie Kirk’s memorial

service Sunday topped both CNN and MSNBC, reaching millions of viewers and putting the Chicago-based network squarely in the cable news mix.

While it still has detractors and skeptics, the former home of “The Andy Griffith Show,” “Bozo’s Circus” and Cubs games, has certainly come a long way.

NewsNation launched in September 2020 as a three-hour block of prime-time programming on the former WGN America, a fledgling cable news network with bold ambitions, a plethora of doubters and few viewers, some of whom were likely searching

in vain for the “Blue Bloods” reruns it replaced.

Early struggles included programming shakeups, management defections and ratings so low the network bordered on irrelevancy, even as it built its news offerings daypart-by-daypart.

Five years later, NewsNation has evolved into a 24/7 cable news network that has carved out its own niche behind the big three — Fox News, MSNBC and CNN — with some big-name stars backed by an army of local TV reporters and a middle-of-the-road

Turn to NewsNation, Page 4

Video shows aftermath of controversial ICE shooting

Agent: Injuries ‘nothing major’ but officials had called them critical

By **Caroline Kubzansky**,
Jason Meisner
and **Madeline Buckley**
Chicago Tribune

In the chaotic first moments when Franklin Park police officers arrived at the scene where an ICE agent fatally shot a man after allegedly being dragged by his fleeing vehicle, they found a pair of agents hunched over Silverio Villegas-Gonzalez.

“He tried to run us over,” one agent says.

A few minutes later, as officers began to canvass the scene, one agent — sporting bloody knees and hands — described his injuries as “nothing major.”

DHS officials originally said that agent was in critical condition following the Sept. 12 traffic stop and subsequent shooting.

In a statement released shortly after the shooting, DHS officials said Villegas-Gonzalez, 38, “refused to follow law enforcement commands and drove his car” at officers trying to conduct a traffic stop, striking one of the ICE agents and dragging him “a significant distance.”

Though it only shows the aftermath, the body camera footage from Franklin Park police offers one of the only glimpses into what happened, given that the ICE agents involved in the shooting were not wearing body cameras. And while it seemingly contradicts at least in part ICE’s original account, the shooting itself was not

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INSIDE

Portillo’s announces departure of CEO

Michael Osanloo abruptly left the company as the chain faces disappointing sales and downsized expansion. **Business**

One of Chicago’s hardest tables to get

How to get holiday reservations at one of the city’s toughest tables, The Walnut Room, with its new executive chef. **Food & Health**

TODAY’S WEATHER

High **72**
Low **58**



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